

AFRICAN HUMANITARIAN AGENCY

Foundational Operational Framework 5

Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework

1. Purpose

This framework establishes the strategic and operational basis through which AfHA will strengthen humanitarian preparedness, enable anticipatory action, and support risk reduction-orientated humanitarian practice across continental, regional and national levels. It defines how AfHA will contribute to readiness, early action and risk-informed coordination in support of Member States, RECs and the wider African humanitarian system. It also clarifies how preparedness and anticipatory action depend on the coordination, financing, information, surge and advocacy functions governed by the companion foundational frameworks.

2. Rationale

The African Humanitarian Agency (AfHA) is being established in a context where humanitarian crises across the continent are becoming more frequent, more complex, and more interconnected. Climate-related hazards, public health emergencies, conflict, displacement, food insecurity, and compounding cross-border risks increasingly interact in ways that strain national capacities and expose the limits of reactive humanitarian systems. In many cases, action still occurs too late, after hazards have already escalated into emergencies, losses have accumulated, and response costs have multiplied. This pattern is financially inefficient, operationally avoidable, and inconsistent with Africa's growing commitment to resilience, disaster risk reduction and African-led humanitarian action.

For this reason, preparedness, anticipatory action and risk reduction must form a central pillar of AfHA's institutional identity and operating model. AfHA cannot be designed only as a mechanism for response after crisis onset. It must also help ensure that Member States, Regional Economic Communities (RECs), and the wider African humanitarian architecture are better prepared before shocks occur, are able to act when early warning signals indicate imminent risk, and progressively strengthen the systems that reduce vulnerability over time.

Preparedness is essential because effective humanitarian action depends on systems, relationships, procedures and capacities that must exist before a crisis. Coordination arrangements, standard operating procedures, focal point systems, logistics pathways, financing triggers, information-sharing routines, and surge mechanisms cannot be improvised in the middle of an emergency without significant delays and inefficiencies. A preparedness-oriented AfHA will therefore help strengthen readiness at continental, regional and national levels, with particular attention to the practical foundations of action.

Anticipatory action is equally important because the continent increasingly has access to warning information that can support earlier action. Early warning systems for weather, climate, drought, food insecurity, public health threats and population movement have improved substantially, yet these signals often do not translate into timely operational decisions. The problem is not only technical forecasting capacity, but also the absence of agreed trigger frameworks, pre-authorised actions, flexible finance, and institutional confidence to act before a crisis fully materialises. AfHA has a clear role to play in helping bridge this warning-to-action gap by linking early warning information, readiness procedures, financing arrangements, and coordination systems.

Risk reduction must also be included because repeated humanitarian crises are not only the product of immediate hazards. They are also shaped by underlying vulnerabilities, exposure, institutional weakness, environmental degradation, governance failures, and social and economic inequalities. Although AfHA is not a development agency, it cannot ignore the structural drivers that repeatedly convert hazards into humanitarian emergencies. It must therefore work in a way that aligns humanitarian preparedness and anticipatory action with wider disaster risk reduction and resilience agendas across the African Union (AU), RECs and Member States.

This framework is also necessary because preparedness, anticipatory action and risk reduction sit at the intersection of several existing African institutional systems. AfHA must work with early warning institutions, public health surveillance systems, national disaster management agencies, climate and weather services, regional coordination structures, Africa CDC, AMHEWAS,

humanitarian actors and financing mechanisms. A dedicated framework is needed to clarify AfHA's role within this landscape, promote complementarity, and avoid duplication.

Finally, this framework is essential to AfHA's legitimacy. If the Agency is seen only as a coordinating mechanism that becomes visible once crises have already escalated, it will remain reactive and limited. If, however, it is able to support earlier, better coordinated and more risk-informed action, it will add strategic value to the African humanitarian architecture. In this sense, preparedness, anticipatory action and risk reduction are not secondary functions. They are central to whether AfHA becomes an institution that merely responds to crisis, or one that helps change the conditions under which crisis unfolds.

In designing its preparedness and anticipatory action architecture, AfHA draws deliberately on the accumulated practice of comparable regional humanitarian and civil protection mechanisms globally. Several lessons from those experiences are directly and immediately relevant to this framework. First, that anticipatory action systems only function when all five enabling conditions are in place simultaneously: a credible forecast or early warning product, a defined trigger threshold, a pre-authorised action set, a pre-positioned or fast-release financing mechanism, and a designated decision authority with the legitimacy and confidence to act. If any one of these conditions is absent, the system stalls at exactly the moment it is most needed. Second, that blueprints, documenting these five conditions for specific hazard types and geographic contexts and approved in advance, are the single most important operational tool for translating early warning into action: without a blueprint in place, every activation begins from first principles under time pressure. Third, that seasonal preparedness calendars, aligning preparedness planning cycles with forecast production cycles, are the mechanism through which the warning-to-action timeline is extended from hours to weeks, allowing preparation to precede rather than respond to forecast confidence. Fourth, that the cost-effectiveness of anticipatory action, consistently demonstrated across multiple hazard types and regions, is AfHA's most powerful advocacy tool with Member States and financing partners: early action is cheaper, faster and more dignified than late response. Fifth, that civil protection pre-positioning and shared reserve systems, in which capacities are maintained at a regional or continental level rather than requiring emergency mobilisation from zero, reduce the response time gap that costs lives. All five lessons are incorporated in this framework, adapted to AfHA's mandate and to African institutional realities.

3. Objectives

This framework pursues the following objectives:

- define AfHA's role in preparedness, anticipatory action and risk reduction within the African humanitarian architecture
- establish a structured approach to readiness planning and preparedness support across AfHA, RECs and Member States
- define how AfHA will support the translation of early warning into anticipatory humanitarian action
- strengthen linkages between humanitarian coordination, early warning systems, public health surveillance, logistics readiness and financing mechanisms
- support harmonised trigger-based planning and pre-agreed action pathways where feasible
- promote a more risk-informed approach to humanitarian coordination and decision-making
- ensure that preparedness and anticipatory action are integrated with surge readiness, information systems, draw-down financing and multi-level coordination
- contribute to stronger alignment between humanitarian action and broader disaster risk reduction and resilience agendas.

4. Scope

This framework applies across AfHA's full institutional perimeter and to all partners contributing to or benefiting from AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action systems. It covers both the institutional and operational dimensions of readiness across the full anticipatory and preparedness cycle.

The framework applies to the following institutions:

- AfHA Headquarters and Regional Centres
- AfHA preparedness, coordination, information, logistics, financing and surge systems
- Member State institutions relevant to disaster management, humanitarian coordination and emergency preparedness
- RECs and Regional Mechanisms
- AU and specialised institutions relevant to early warning, public health, climate, food security and humanitarian action
- approved humanitarian, technical and financing partners contributing to preparedness and anticipatory action.

It covers the following functions and activities:

- readiness planning and readiness assessment
- contingency and scenario-based planning
- trigger development, monitoring, validation and activation
- anticipatory action protocols and blueprint management
- preparedness financing and draw-down readiness
- cross-border preparedness and mutual support
- logistics and information readiness
- seasonal preparedness planning and outlook-linked preparation
- learning and review related to preparedness and early action
- humanitarian dimensions of risk reduction and resilience support.

4.1 Relationship with companion frameworks

This framework is the operational home for preparedness, anticipatory action and the humanitarian dimensions of risk reduction. It defines readiness planning, contingency planning, trigger architecture, blueprint management, seasonal preparedness calendars, cross-border preparedness and learning. It does not replace the companion frameworks that govern AfHA's coordination structures, financing windows, information products, surge systems or advocacy pathways. Where this framework refers to those areas, it does so to define the preparedness and anticipatory action requirements they must support.

5. Guiding principles

Eight guiding principles govern AfHA's approach to preparedness, anticipatory action and risk reduction. These principles apply equally to how AfHA designs its internal systems and how it supports Member States and RECs, and they inform the interpretation of every subsequent section of this framework.

5.1 African ownership

Preparedness and anticipatory action systems supported by AfHA must reinforce African institutions, African leadership and African decision-making. This means that triggers are developed through African institutional processes, blueprints are approved by African governance structures, and the decision to act is made by African authorities rather than prompted by external pressure. External technical support to preparedness system design is legitimate and valuable; external control over activation decisions is not.

5.2 Subsidiarity

Preparedness and early action should be anchored as close as possible to the point of risk. The most effective preparedness is local; the most effective anticipatory action is national. AfHA's contribution is to add continental and regional value where national and local systems cannot reach alone, particularly for cross-border risks, multi-country crises and situations where regional

coordination adds material value to national efforts. AfHA should therefore resist the temptation to centralise preparedness functions that belong closer to affected communities.

5.3 Risk-informed humanitarian action

Preparedness and action should be based on forward-looking analysis of hazards, exposure, vulnerability and institutional capacity, not only on the most recent crisis report. Risk-informed action means looking at what might happen over the coming season, not only at what is happening today. It requires investment in hazard analysis, vulnerability mapping, scenario development and impact-based forecasting as inputs to planning, not merely as academic products.

5.4 Early action where evidence justifies it

Where credible warning information and agreed trigger thresholds exist, AfHA should support action before full crisis manifestation rather than waiting for impact to intensify. The evidence base for early action has grown substantially: in repeated contexts across multiple hazard types, acting on a forecast has been shown to be more cost-effective, more dignified and more protective of lives and livelihoods than waiting for confirmed disaster onset. AfHA should build on this evidence base and use it actively in its advocacy for preparedness investment and anticipatory financing.

5.5 Practical readiness

Preparedness must be operationally useful. Plans, rosters, stock arrangements, trigger thresholds and procedures should be realistic, tested and actionable in the specific geographic, institutional and logistical contexts where they will be needed. A preparedness plan that exists only on paper, that has never been tested in an exercise, that contains contact details that are out of date, and that requires resources that are not actually available, is not readiness: it is documentation. AfHA should apply a practical readiness standard that distinguishes between plan existence and genuine operational capability.

5.6 Multi-hazard integration

Preparedness and anticipatory action should account for multiple, interacting hazards and cascading risks rather than treating each threat in isolation. Africa's humanitarian landscape is characterised by compound and intersecting risks: a drought that triggers food insecurity that triggers displacement that occurs alongside a conflict that limits access to the affected population. Single-hazard planning produces single-hazard readiness that fails in the face of compound events. AfHA should promote and model multi-hazard preparedness approaches across all its systems.

5.7 Complementarity

AfHA should strengthen and connect existing preparedness and early warning systems rather than duplicate the mandates of national, regional or specialised institutions. The continental early warning system, regional meteorological and climate centres, national disaster management authorities, Africa CDC and regional food security monitoring systems all exist and have established expertise. AfHA's role is to translate their outputs into humanitarian action, not to replicate their functions.

5.8 Learning and adaptation

Preparedness and anticipatory action systems must evolve through simulation, after-action review and practical experience. A preparedness system that does not learn is a system that gradually becomes less relevant as hazard patterns, institutional landscapes and operational realities change. AfHA should build structured learning mechanisms into every element of this framework, so that the system improves continuously rather than crystallising around its initial design.

6. Core pillars of the framework

The framework is organised around five strategic pillars. Each pillar represents a distinct but interconnected dimension of AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action mandate. Effective performance across all five pillars is required for AfHA to fulfil its role as a forward-looking continental humanitarian institution.

6.1 Preparedness systems and readiness planning

This pillar covers the institutional, procedural and operational arrangements that must be in place before a crisis begins. It includes contingency planning, readiness assessment, focal point and coordination structures, standard operating procedures, logistics readiness, information preparedness and financing readiness. It is the foundation on which all other pillars rest: without functional preparedness systems, anticipatory action has nowhere to land and surge readiness has no procedures to follow.

6.2 Anticipatory action architecture

This pillar covers the specific systems required to act before crisis escalation. It includes trigger design and validation, impact-based forecast interpretation, pre-agreed action plans documented as blueprints, decision authority protocols, anticipatory financing linkage, and the post-action review process through which the system learns and improves. The anticipatory action architecture is the most technically specific pillar in the framework and is described in detail in sections 11 and 12.

6.3 Risk-informed coordination and analysis

This pillar ensures that AfHA's coordination, information and planning functions are consistently informed by forward-looking multi-hazard risk analysis, not only by immediate crisis reports. It includes seasonal risk outlooks, hazard and vulnerability mapping, risk interpretation for decision support, and the integration of risk analysis into preparedness planning. This pillar is the analytical foundation that gives the other pillars their anticipatory, rather than merely reactive, character.

6.4 Cross-border preparedness and regional solidarity

This pillar addresses the reality that many of Africa's most serious humanitarian risks are transboundary. It includes shared regional scenario planning, cross-border trigger interpretation, regional solidarity arrangements, mutual support protocols, and interoperable preparedness systems across RECs and Member States. This pillar is the expression, in preparedness terms, of the continental solidarity principle that underpins AfHA's mandate.

6.5 Linkage with disaster risk reduction and resilience agendas

This pillar ensures that AfHA's humanitarian preparedness work contributes to, and draws from, the broader continental and national efforts to reduce recurrent vulnerability. It includes alignment with Sendai Framework implementation, support for risk-aware institutional practice, contribution of humanitarian learning to risk reduction planning, and the promotion of preparedness measures that reduce likely humanitarian impacts of future hazards.

7. AfHA's role in preparedness

AfHA's role in preparedness is not to replace national disaster management authorities or REC preparedness systems. Its role is to add continental and regional value across five specific functions that national and REC systems cannot perform on their own:

- supporting harmonised readiness approaches across Member States and RECs, so that when cross-border crises occur, coordination arrangements are already familiar and compatible rather than being negotiated under time pressure
- strengthening preparedness for multi-country and cross-border risks that exceed the planning horizon and institutional reach of any single member state or REC
- linking readiness planning with AfHA's coordination, surge, information and financing systems, so that preparedness is connected to practical decision pathways rather than remaining an isolated planning exercise
- identifying systemic gaps in continental preparedness that require regional or continental attention and that individual Member States cannot address independently

- helping ensure that preparedness is operationally real, not merely documented: tested through exercises, linked to actual logistics and financing arrangements, and reviewed regularly against changed conditions.

Preparedness support should be both institutional and operational. It should cover not only plans but also people, systems, information flows, financing arrangements and logistics readiness. AfHA should assess its own preparedness function against this operational standard, not only against the existence of plans and procedures.

8. AfHA's role in anticipatory action

AfHA's role in anticipatory action is to bridge the gap between available early warning information and timely, pre-authorised humanitarian action. This is AfHA's most distinctive contribution to the African humanitarian architecture, and the function that best expresses its added value relative to existing mechanisms. AfHA is not expected to replace technical forecasting bodies; its role is to ensure that the humanitarian implications of warning information are understood, that pre-agreed action pathways are in place, and that the institutional and financial conditions for early action are ready before the warning arrives.

AfHA will add value in anticipatory action through the following functions:

- supporting interpretation of warning information from the continental early warning system and other recognised technical institutions, translating hazard probability and intensity information into projected humanitarian consequences
- facilitating the development of hazard-specific anticipatory action triggers and blueprints, working with Member States, RECs and technical partners to define the five interlocking elements required for each anticipatory action scenario
- linking trigger-based readiness to the draw-down mechanism and other anticipatory financing instruments, ensuring that resources can be released within the available lead time once a trigger is confirmed
- supporting coordination between Member States, RECs and partners around pre-agreed early actions, so that multiple actors can mobilise simultaneously rather than sequentially
- documenting and refining anticipatory action approaches through practice and learning, building an evidence base of what works across different hazard types and regional contexts
- advocating for the cost-effectiveness of anticipatory action to Member States and financing partners, using post-action review evidence to demonstrate that early action consistently reduces the human and financial cost of humanitarian response.

AfHA is not expected to replace technical forecasting bodies. Its role is to support the humanitarian use of warning information.

9. AfHA's role in humanitarian dimensions of risk reduction

AfHA's mandate is humanitarian, but the most effective humanitarian institution is one that also reduces the conditions under which humanitarian crises repeatedly occur. AfHA should therefore support the humanitarian dimensions of risk reduction without displacing the mandates of dedicated disaster risk reduction and development institutions.

AfHA's specific contribution to risk reduction includes the following:

- identifying patterns of recurrent humanitarian risk by analysing the accumulated record of crises, responses and preparedness gaps across the continent, producing assessments that support risk-informed investment in preparedness rather than purely reactive response budgeting
- encouraging preparedness measures that reduce likely humanitarian impacts, working with Member States and RECs to translate risk analysis into operational preparedness investments

- supporting better linkage between emergency preparedness and disaster risk reduction planning, ensuring that AfHA's preparedness work is connected to Sendai Framework implementation, national disaster risk reduction strategies and continental risk reduction frameworks
- ensuring that after-action learning from humanitarian responses contributes to reduced vulnerability in future cycles, by systematically feeding lessons from activations into preparedness planning and risk reduction advocacy
- promoting more risk-aware institutional practice across regional and continental systems, so that humanitarian coordination bodies, financing mechanisms and surge systems progressively incorporate forward-looking risk perspectives rather than remaining oriented only toward current crises.

This role should remain complementary to the mandates of dedicated disaster risk reduction and development institutions.

10. Preparedness components

AfHA-supported preparedness should include at least six operational components. These components are mutually reinforcing: information readiness informs readiness planning; logistics readiness is a precondition for effective contingency planning; coordination readiness enables everything else. AfHA should assess progress against all six components rather than treating any single component as sufficient.

10.1 Readiness planning

Readiness planning provides the institutional and operational architecture through which preparedness commitments are translated into standing arrangements. A readiness plan is not a crisis response plan; it is a description of the state of standing readiness that AfHA and its partners maintain between crises, and a record of what will happen when a crisis begins.

Readiness plans should clarify at minimum the following:

- institutional roles and focal points by function and level
- likely hazard scenarios by region with their probability and seasonal patterns
- coordination arrangements including who convenes, who reports and who decides
- information-sharing pathways and contact protocols
- escalation and activation thresholds with reference to the relevant blueprints
- logistics and movement arrangements and the institutional actors responsible for them
- surge support options including roster contacts and activation procedures
- financing readiness including pre-approved ceilings and draw-down procedures.

10.2 Contingency planning

Contingency planning takes the readiness architecture and applies it to specific high-risk scenarios, producing operational plans that specify what AfHA and its partners will do if a defined scenario materialises. Contingency plans should be scenario-based, linked to realistic operational consequences, and reviewed and updated at least annually based on changed risk conditions. Priority scenarios for contingency planning should be identified from the seasonal risk outlook and from the pattern of recurrent humanitarian events in each region.

10.3 Readiness assessments

Readiness assessments provide the evidence base for preparedness investment and prioritisation. AfHA should support periodic readiness assessments at continental, regional and national levels, using a common assessment methodology that allows comparison across contexts and tracking of progress over time. Assessment findings should feed directly into preparedness planning, capacity development programming and advocacy for preparedness financing. Readiness assessments

should be conducted with rather than for Member States and RECs, building assessment capacity alongside generating assessment findings.

10.4 Logistics preparedness

Logistics preparedness covers the pre-crisis work needed to ensure that physical supplies, transport, corridor access and communications can be mobilised when needed. This framework defines the preparedness requirements that logistics systems must support. The operational standards for surge readiness, deployment preparation and logistics-related capacity are governed by the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework, while the financing of pre-positioning and draw-down readiness is governed by the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework.

10.5 Information readiness

Information readiness means that the data flows, focal point contacts, reporting formats and common operating picture arrangements needed for preparedness and anticipatory action are established and tested before the crisis begins. The Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework governs the data standards, product formats, verification procedures and release protocols that support these functions. This framework defines the preparedness and trigger-related information requirements that those systems must meet.

10.6 Coordination readiness

Coordination readiness means that the institutional relationships, coordination rhythms, action tracking methods, briefing pathways and activation procedures required for preparedness and anticipatory action are known in advance by all relevant parties. The Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework governs the coordination structures, single-entry arrangements and activation pathways through which these relationships are convened. This framework defines the preparedness and anticipatory action content that those coordination structures must support.

11. Anticipatory action architecture

Anticipatory action does not happen spontaneously. It requires a deliberate institutional architecture built around five inter-dependent elements that must all be in place before any activation can work as intended. This architecture is the operational heart of Framework 5, and its design quality determines whether AfHA can genuinely support early action or can only advocate for it. The five elements, introduced in the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework in the context of anticipatory financing procedures, are elaborated here as the operational framework that governs all anticipatory action activity.

The five elements must be understood as a system, not a checklist. A mechanism that has four of the five elements in place is not 80% ready for anticipatory action: it is 0% ready, because the missing element will prevent activation at the critical moment. AfHA should therefore assess its anticipatory action readiness across all five elements for each hazard-specific scenario, and should not claim anticipatory action capability for any scenario where any element is incomplete.

11.1 Element 1: Trigger conditions

A trigger is a pre-agreed, observable, hazard-specific and geographically referenced threshold derived from a recognised early warning or forecast system, at which a defined set of pre-authorised actions is automatically or near-automatically activated. The trigger is the mechanism through which scientific forecast information is converted into an institutional decision without requiring a full deliberative process at the moment of crisis.

Triggers must be designed with the following characteristics:

- specificity: a trigger must specify the exact indicator being monitored, the source institution providing the data, the precise threshold level at which the trigger condition is met, and the geographic area to which it applies
- lead time alignment: the trigger threshold must be set at a level that provides sufficient lead time for the pre-agreed actions to be meaningfully implemented before the anticipated impact; a trigger that fires three hours before a flood peak is not an anticipatory action trigger
- technical credibility: triggers must be based on indicators that the designated early warning authority monitors and can confirm, not on informal reports or unverified secondary information
- humanitarian relevance: triggers should be expressed in terms of forecast impact on human populations where possible, not only in terms of physical hazard parameters; this requires the translation of forecast information into impact-based projections
- pre-agreement: triggers must be agreed, documented and communicated to all relevant parties, including the financing authority, before any activation is needed; a trigger that is determined retrospectively is a justification, not a trigger.

11.2 Element 2: Pre-authorised actions

Pre-authorised actions are the specific, defined set of activities that will be initiated when a trigger condition is confirmed. They are the operational content of anticipatory action: what will actually be done, by whom, where, with what resources, over what timeline. Pre-authorisation means that these actions have been approved in advance by the relevant institutional authority, so that they can be initiated immediately on trigger confirmation without requiring a new deliberative approval.

Pre-authorised actions should be designed with the following characteristics:

- specificity: each action should describe what will be done, who will do it, where, and with what inputs; vague actions such as 'strengthen coordination' are not implementable under time pressure
- proportionality to lead time: the set of pre-authorised actions must be achievable within the available lead time; actions that take longer to implement than the lead time allows are not early actions
- implementability: each action must be grounded in realistic assumptions about available capacity, logistics, access and financing; an action that cannot actually be implemented in the identified context is not a pre-authorised action
- humanitarian value: each action must have a clear and articulable basis for its anticipated humanitarian benefit, so that the action set can be defended in post-action review
- documentation: the full set of pre-authorised actions for each scenario should be documented in the hazard-specific blueprint described in section 12.

Standard categories of pre-authorised action include: enhanced monitoring and situation reporting at a defined increased frequency; risk communication and early warning messaging to at-risk communities through agreed channels; pre-positioning of critical supplies to designated staging areas or community distribution points; placement of surge roster members on immediate standby or advance deployment to the likely impact area; early support to national or regional coordination structures; activation of contingency finance windows through the draw-down procedures in the financing framework; and initiation of logistics arrangements, including corridor activation and transport contracting.

11.3 Element 3: Pre-positioned or fast-release resources

Anticipatory action is only feasible if the resources required to implement the pre-authorised actions are either already positioned near the likely impact area or can be released from a central window within the available lead time. The resource element of the anticipatory action architecture connects this framework to the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework, the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework, and the Capacity Development and Surge Readiness Framework.

AfHA's resource readiness for anticipatory action should include the following:

- a pre-positioned financial window within the anticipatory action financing stream described in the financing framework, with a defined standing allocation that can be released on trigger confirmation within 24 to 72 hours
- pre-positioned or rapidly accessible physical supplies, maintained by AfHA regional logistics depots or through pre-agreed access to partner stockpiles, for the most common pre-authorised action types across priority scenarios
- roster members on standby protocols for high-probability scenarios, so that the administrative and logistical preparations for deployment are complete before activation rather than initiated after it
- pre-agreed logistics arrangements, including corridor access, transport contracts and border facilitation, for priority deployment routes
- fast-track procurement procedures for items that cannot be pre-positioned but must be obtained rapidly on activation.

11.4 Element 4: Designated decision authority

Every anticipatory action scenario must have a clearly designated authority who is responsible for confirming the trigger condition and authorising activation of the pre-agreed actions. Decision authority is determined in advance and documented in the blueprint, not assigned at the moment of decision. The designation of decision authority must be calibrated to the available lead time: if the lead time for a given scenario is three weeks, board-level approval may be operationally feasible; if the lead time is 48 hours, only Executive Secretary or pre-delegated authority is viable.

Decision authority for AfHA's anticipatory actions should follow a tiered structure consistent with the delegation framework in the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework. The key elements of the decision authority structure are as follows:

- trigger confirmation: the designated early warning authority, not AfHA, confirms that the trigger threshold has been met; AfHA's role is to receive, validate and communicate the confirmation, not to make the primary forecast judgment
- activation decision: the designated AfHA authority, at the level specified in the relevant blueprint, reviews the trigger confirmation and initiates the activation of pre-agreed actions within the authorised financial ceiling
- immediate notification: the Governing Board, relevant Member States, the affected REC and key partners are notified simultaneously with the activation decision
- pre-delegation provision: blueprints for short-lead-time scenarios must specify the pre-delegated authority who may act on behalf of the Executive Secretary if the Executive Secretary is unavailable when the trigger fires
- decision record: every activation decision must be documented, including the trigger confirmation, the decision rationale, the authority exercised and the time of decision, creating the accountability record for post-action review.

11.5 Element 5: Post-action review

Post-action review is the fifth and, over time, the most strategically important element of the anticipatory action architecture. It is the mechanism through which AfHA's anticipatory action system learns from every activation, improving trigger calibration, action design, decision protocols and financing procedures through accumulated operational experience. Without systematic post-action review, AfHA's anticipatory action system will improve only through intuition rather than evidence.

A post-action review should be conducted following every anticipatory action activation, whether the activation was followed by the anticipated humanitarian crisis, whether it was not followed by the anticipated crisis (a false positive), or whether an anticipated crisis materialised without activation occurring (a false negative). Each of these scenarios produces different and equally valuable learning. Post-action reviews should address at minimum the following questions:

- was the trigger correctly calibrated? Did it fire at the right level of forecast probability, too early, or too late?

- were the pre-agreed actions implemented as planned within the available lead time, and if not, what caused the shortfall?
- were the resources available, accessible and sufficient, and were the administrative and logistics arrangements adequate?
- what humanitarian impact did the early action have, and can this be compared to a modelled baseline of what would have happened without early action?
- was the decision authority correctly designated and was the activation decision made in the required time?
- what specific changes to the trigger threshold, action set, financing procedures, logistics arrangements or decision protocol would improve the system for the next activation?

Post-action review findings should be reported to the Governing Board, shared with Member States and RECs involved in the activation, communicated to financing partners, and used to update the relevant blueprint within a defined period. The accumulated record of post-action reviews is AfHA's primary evidence base for advocacy on anticipatory action, and should be treated as a strategic institutional asset.

12. Hazard-specific anticipatory action blueprints

An anticipatory action blueprint is a single document that brings together all five elements of the anticipatory action architecture for a specific hazard type and geographic context. It is the central operational tool of AfHA's anticipatory action system: the document that makes it possible to act rapidly and with pre-agreed authority when a trigger fires, and the reference document against which post-action performance is assessed. Without approved blueprints in place, AfHA cannot credibly claim anticipatory action capability for any specific scenario.

Each blueprint should document the following elements, all of which must be completed and approved before the blueprint is considered operational:

- scenario definition: the hazard type, geographic area, affected population profile, and typical humanitarian consequences that the blueprint addresses
- trigger conditions: the specific indicator, source institution, threshold level, geographic scope and lead time, as described in section 11.1
- impact-based forecast linkage: the impact-based forecast product or model that translates the trigger indicator into projected humanitarian consequence, and the source institution responsible for producing it
- pre-authorised actions: the specific, implementable set of actions that will be initiated on trigger confirmation, including the responsible actor for each action, the resource requirements and the implementation timeline
- designated decision authority: the specific role or individual authorised to confirm the trigger and initiate activation, with a named pre-delegation provision for short-lead-time scenarios
- resource readiness provisions: the financing window and ceiling available for activation, the logistics and supply pre-positioning arrangements, and the surge standby protocol where applicable
- trigger confirmation procedure: the step-by-step process for receiving, validating and communicating trigger confirmation from the designated early warning authority
- post-action review schedule: the timeline and format for the post-action review that will follow each activation
- blueprint approval record: the governing authority that approved the blueprint and the date of approval, with a defined review cycle.

Blueprints should be developed through a structured process involving AfHA's information and analysis function, the financing function, the operations and surge functions, and relevant external partners including the early warning authority and member state focal points for the scenario area. The development process is itself a preparedness activity: it builds the institutional relationships and shared understanding needed for rapid, confident activation.

AfHA should establish a continental blueprint register that records the status of all blueprints under development and all approved operational blueprints. The register should identify priority scenarios for which blueprints are needed but not yet developed, and should track the progress of blueprint development against a defined schedule. The ambition for Phase 1 is to have at least two to three approved operational blueprints for the most common and most forecastable hazard types across AfHA's regions; Phase 2 and Phase 3 should expand coverage progressively across hazard types and geographic areas.

13. Seasonal preparedness calendar and outlook-linked preparation

One of the most effective tools for extending the warning-to-action timeline from hours to weeks is the seasonal preparedness calendar. A seasonal preparedness calendar aligns AfHA's readiness and planning activities with the forecast production cycle of the continental and regional climate, health and food security monitoring systems, so that preparation begins when forecast confidence first emerges for a coming season rather than when impact is already imminent.

The seasonal preparedness calendar operates on the following logic. Continental and regional climate and forecast centres produce seasonal outlooks on a predictable schedule, typically several months before the relevant season begins. These outlooks provide probability estimates of above-normal or below-normal precipitation, temperature, drought conditions, and in some regions, tropical cyclone activity. Equivalent forecasts exist for food security, public health transmission seasons, and in some contexts, conflict-related displacement patterns. When these outlooks indicate elevated risk for specific areas in the coming season, AfHA should initiate a defined preparedness response even before any individual event has formed.

The seasonal preparedness calendar should include the following elements:

- seasonal forecast intake dates: the dates on which AfHA will formally receive and review seasonal outlook products from each designated source institution, aligned with the production schedule of those institutions
- seasonal risk assessment: a structured review of seasonal outlook products to identify areas and populations at elevated humanitarian risk in the coming season, producing the seasonal humanitarian outlook described in Framework 3
- blueprint activation review: a formal check, at the beginning of each risk season, of whether blueprints are approved and resources are in place for all priority scenarios identified in the seasonal risk assessment
- preparedness action period: the window between the seasonal risk assessment and the onset of the forecast risk period, during which pre-positioning, roster standby protocols, financing readiness checks and partner coordination are completed
- heightened monitoring period: the period during which the forecast risk window is open and trigger indicators are monitored at increased frequency, with regular trigger status updates shared with decision authorities and partners
- post-season review: a structured review after the risk season closes, assessing whether activations occurred, whether false positives or false negatives were observed, and what changes to the blueprint or calendar are needed for the next cycle.

The seasonal preparedness calendar should be published annually and distributed to AfHA's Regional Centres, relevant RECs and member state focal points, so that they can align their own preparedness activities with AfHA's cycle. A shared preparedness calendar is itself a coordination tool: it creates a common rhythm around which regional and national preparedness actions can be organised, reducing the risk that AfHA's anticipatory action activities are unilateral or unsynchronised with the institutions whose support is needed for implementation.

14. Cross-border preparedness and mutual support

A defining characteristic of Africa's humanitarian risk landscape is its transboundary nature. Droughts, floods, epidemic outbreaks, displacement flows and conflict dynamics routinely cross-borders, affecting populations in multiple countries and requiring coordination between national systems that may have different preparedness levels, different institutional capacities and different political relationships. AfHA's continental mandate positions it as the most appropriate institution to lead cross-border preparedness planning and to facilitate regional solidarity arrangements.

AfHA should support cross-border preparedness through the following activities:

- shared regional scenario planning that addresses hazard types and geographic contexts where cross-border risk is a primary feature, developing shared understanding of likely crisis dynamics across the boundary
- mapping of cross-border risks and corridors, identifying the physical, institutional and regulatory factors that enable or constrain cross-border humanitarian access and movement
- alignment of focal points and communication chains between neighbouring Member States, so that cross-border information sharing is routine rather than exceptional
- cross-border trigger interpretation, addressing scenarios where a trigger for anticipatory action spans more than one member state or requires coordination between different national decision authorities
- regional solidarity arrangements and mutual support protocols, defining in advance how Member States and RECs will support each other in the event of a cross-border or overwhelming national crisis
- integration of cross-border preparedness with the coordination SOP on cross-border coordination and mutual support.

Regional Centres and RECs should be central to all cross-border preparedness activities. AfHA Headquarters provides the continental framework and standard methodologies; Regional Centres apply them to the specific cross-border dynamics of their regions; RECs provide the political legitimacy and institutional relationships through which mutual support arrangements can be formalised and honoured.

15. Linkage with AMHEWAS, Africa CDC and RECs

The effectiveness of AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action system depends fundamentally on the quality of its information exchange relationships with the institutions that generate the early warning and surveillance data on which triggers and seasonal risk assessments are based. Three relationships are of primary importance, and each requires a formal, operational linkage that goes beyond a general cooperation agreement.

The relationship with the continental multi-hazard early warning and advisory system is AfHA's most important data partnership for natural hazard anticipatory action. As established in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework and the Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework, the continental early warning system is AfHA's designated primary source for multi-hazard forecast and early warning data. In the preparedness and anticipatory action context, this relationship involves the following specific functions:

- receipt of seasonal outlook products on a schedule aligned with the seasonal preparedness calendar
- receipt of sub-seasonal and event-specific forecast products when elevated risk is identified
- formal trigger confirmation for activations in natural hazard scenarios, where the early warning authority's confirmation is the primary evidence for the activation decision
- joint development of impact-based forecast products that translate hazard probability into projected humanitarian consequence for priority scenarios
- joint review of trigger calibration after each activation, contributing the early warning authority's perspective to the post-action review.

The relationship with Africa CDC is AfHA's primary linkage for public health early warning and preparedness. Public health emergencies are among Africa's most significant and most frequently recurring humanitarian drivers. AfHA should maintain a formal information exchange arrangement with Africa CDC covering health risk monitoring, epidemic and outbreak early warning, health system capacity information relevant to humanitarian preparedness, and health-related trigger development for anticipatory action in public health scenarios.

The relationship with RECs is AfHA's primary regional institutional partnership for preparedness implementation. RECs are the institutions through which AfHA's continental preparedness frameworks are translated into regional and national practice, and they are the political authorities that make cross-border solidarity arrangements credible. AfHA should maintain formal preparedness coordination arrangements with each REC, aligned with the regional partnership protocols in the Continental Humanitarian Coordination and Partnership Framework.

16. Linkage with AfHA financing systems

Preparedness and anticipatory action cannot function without financing readiness. The most carefully designed trigger and the most detailed blueprint are operationally worthless if the resources needed to implement the pre-authorised actions cannot be released within the available lead time. Financing readiness is therefore not a supporting function of this framework; it is an enabling condition, and its absence is a direct cause of anticipatory action failure.

Framework 2 remains the operational home for financing governance, resource mobilisation, approval thresholds, eligible expenditure categories, release procedures and financial reporting. This framework defines the preparedness and blueprint requirements that those financing arrangements must enable within the available lead time.

The specific financing linkages required by this framework are as follows:

- the anticipatory action financing stream described in the Humanitarian Financing and Resource Mobilisation Framework, which provides the pre-positioned or fast-release financial window from which approved blueprint activations are funded
- the emergency contingency financing stream, which provides the rapid resource release mechanism for sudden-onset events that do not have an approved blueprint but require immediate action
- the preparedness financing provisions, supporting the pre-crisis investments in readiness planning, contingency planning, logistics pre-positioning, simulation exercises and blueprint development that make anticipatory action possible
- the funding approval and accountability procedures that determine the decision authority for each financing window, calibrated to the lead time constraints of each scenario
- the post-action financial reporting requirements, ensuring that anticipatory action expenditures are documented and reported in a way that sustains partner confidence and supports future financing commitments.

A specific requirement of this framework is that every approved blueprint must have a confirmed financing source before it is classified as operational. A blueprint without a confirmed financing source is a planning document, not an operational tool. AfHA should therefore conduct an annual financing readiness review for all approved blueprints, confirming that the required financial windows are capitalised and accessible for each scenario.

17. Linkage with surge readiness

Preparedness and anticipatory action are inseparable from surge readiness. In many scenarios, the most critical early action is not the procurement or delivery of supplies but the deployment of coordination, information or technical support to strengthen the capacity of Member States and RECs to manage an escalating situation before it exceeds their own resources. This makes surge readiness a direct operational input to anticipatory action, not merely a parallel function.

The specific surge readiness linkages required by this framework are as follows:

- surge roster management: anticipatory action blueprints should specify whether a surge standby protocol is part of the pre-authorised action set for a given scenario, and if so, which roster functional categories should be placed on standby at trigger confirmation
- training and certification standards: the capacity development framework should include specific training modules on anticipatory action procedures, trigger interpretation, blueprint management and post-action review, so that roster members deployed in anticipatory action scenarios are prepared for the specific demands of early deployment
- partner surge integration: partner-linked standby support arrangements should specify whether partner surge capacity is available for anticipatory action deployments, and under what conditions it can be activated alongside or instead of continental roster capacity
- deployment readiness systems: the administrative and logistical preparations for surge deployment should be included in blueprint design, so that deployment order templates, briefing packages and duty-of-care arrangements for anticipatory deployments are ready before activation.

In some contexts, the most important early action may be to place surge capacities on standby or deploy limited technical support early.

18. Information and analysis requirements

Preparedness and anticipatory action depend entirely on the quality, timeliness and accessibility of the information systems described in the Humanitarian Data and Information Interoperability Framework. Framework 3 remains the operational home for information governance, data standards, product design, verification procedures and release protocols. This section defines only the specific information and analysis requirements that Framework 5 places on those systems.

The specific information requirements of this framework are as follows:

- data collection, validation and sharing procedures that maintain the currency and quality of the trigger indicator data streams on which blueprint activations depend
- common operating picture management in heightened readiness mode, increasing the frequency and specificity of updates when a seasonal risk period is active or a trigger threshold is being approached
- humanitarian situation reporting that distinguishes explicitly between routine risk monitoring, heightened readiness and active anticipatory action phases, with product frequency and content calibrated to each phase
- ethical and protection-sensitive data use protocols that apply to anticipatory action scenarios, including the use of displacement prediction models and population vulnerability data in trigger design
- trigger notes and readiness briefs as described in the information framework, produced within the timelines specified in each blueprint.

Information products should distinguish between routine risk monitoring, heightened readiness and active anticipatory action phases.

19. Preparedness and anticipatory action cycle

AfHA should structure its work around a repeating preparedness and anticipatory action cycle, ensuring that preparedness is treated as a continuous institutional process rather than a one-off planning exercise or a crisis-triggered scramble. The cycle is not linear: several phases occur simultaneously, and the system should be capable of running different phases in different regions at the same time. The cycle comprises nine phases, each with specific activities and outputs.

Table 1: Preparedness and anticipatory action cycle

Phase	Key activities	Primary output
Risk monitoring and analysis	Continuous monitoring of hazard indicators, seasonal forecasts and vulnerability trends; review of seasonal outlook products from designated institutions	Updated risk picture and seasonal humanitarian outlook
Readiness assessment	Structured assessment of preparedness systems at regional and national levels against common criteria; identification of gaps and priorities	Readiness assessment report with priority actions
Contingency and preparedness planning	Development or update of contingency plans for priority scenarios; blueprint development or review; logistics pre-positioning planning	Updated contingency plans and approved blueprints
Trigger identification and refinement	Identification or review of trigger conditions for approved blueprints; calibration of thresholds against forecast accuracy data from previous seasons	Confirmed trigger conditions for all active blueprints
Anticipatory decision support	Heightened monitoring when forecast risk is elevated; trigger status updates to decision authorities; pre-activation checks on resource and administrative readiness	Trigger status notes and pre-activation readiness confirmation
Early action implementation	Activation of pre-agreed actions on trigger confirmation; initiation of financing release, logistics arrangements and surge protocols; partner notification	Activation record and implementation status updates
Response transition where necessary	If the anticipated event occurs, smooth transition from anticipatory action to emergency response coordination, preserving continuity of information and coordination products	Activation-to-response transition brief
After-action review and learning	Structured post-action review assessing trigger calibration, action implementation, resource adequacy, decision authority and humanitarian impact	Post-action review report with specific recommendations
Revision of plans, triggers and systems	Implementation of post-action review recommendations; update of blueprints, trigger thresholds and financing arrangements; revision of seasonal preparedness calendar	Updated blueprints and revised seasonal calendar

This cyclical model ensures that preparedness is a living institutional function, not a static product. Each cycle generates learning that improves the next cycle, so that AfHA's anticipatory action system becomes more accurate, faster and more cost-effective over time.

20. Capacity development implications

This framework makes specific and substantial demands on AfHA's capacity development system as described in Framework 4. The capacity needed to design, manage and activate a multi-hazard anticipatory action system is qualitatively different from the capacity needed for reactive humanitarian coordination. AfHA should ensure that the capacity development implications of this framework are fully reflected in the continental competency framework and the training programme design described in Framework 4.

The priority capacity development needs arising from this framework are the following:

- contingency planning: the methodology for scenario-based contingency planning linked to realistic operational consequences and financing readiness
- trigger design and interpretation: the technical and institutional process for developing, validating and refining trigger conditions, including the statistical interpretation of forecast probability information in a humanitarian decision-making context
- impact-based forecasting: the methods for translating hazard forecast information into projected humanitarian consequence, and for communicating uncertainty ranges to decision-making audiences
- multi-hazard analysis: the analytical approach to compound and cascading risks, including the assessment of interaction effects between concurrent hazards
- cross-border preparedness: the methods for scenario planning, trigger interpretation and coordination that address transboundary risks
- anticipatory financing procedures: the administrative and documentation requirements of trigger-based financing activation, as described in the financing framework
- risk communication: the methods for communicating forecast-based risk information to affected populations and decision-makers in a way that supports rather than undermines appropriate protective action
- logistics readiness: the operational knowledge needed to plan and manage pre-positioning, corridor activation and transport contracting for anticipatory action scenarios
- preparedness exercises and simulation: the design and facilitation of exercises that test anticipatory action systems, including the realistic simulation of trigger conditions and decision authority processes.

These needs should be addressed specifically through Framework 4's certification and competency standards, ensuring that anticipatory action capacity is a required element of practitioner and specialist certification for relevant roster functional categories, not an optional add-on.

21. Learning and continuous improvement

AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action system will only remain accurate and effective if it learns systematically from every element of its operational experience. Preparedness systems and anticipatory action triggers are not fixed designs; they are hypotheses about what will happen and what will work, subject to revision in the light of evidence. AfHA should treat learning not as a retrospective obligation but as a core operational function that begins with the design of each preparedness activity and ends only when the lessons from that activity are documented, assigned and implemented.

The framework requires structured learning mechanisms across the following activities:

- trigger calibration review: after each season in which a trigger scenario was active, whether or not activation occurred, AfHA should review whether the trigger threshold was correctly

set relative to the observed forecast accuracy and humanitarian outcomes, and adjust accordingly

- decision protocol review: after each activation or near-activation, AfHA should assess whether the decision authority designation and the decision timeline were appropriate, and whether any changes are needed
- coordination arrangement review: after each anticipatory action activation, assessing whether the coordination between AfHA, RECs, Member States and partners functioned as planned and what improvements are needed
- financing readiness review: after each activation, assessing whether the financing was released on time and within the available lead time, and whether the approval procedures created any delays
- logistics planning review: after each activation, assessing whether pre-positioned supplies, transport arrangements and corridor access performed as planned
- blueprint realism review: after each season, assessing whether the pre-authorised action sets in approved blueprints remain realistic given any changes in institutional capacity, logistics availability or population dynamics.

Preparedness systems should be living systems, not fixed documents.

22. Risks and mitigation

The following table summarises the principal risks to AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action system and the mitigation measures AfHA will apply. The risk register should be reviewed annually in the context of the seasonal preparedness calendar review and updated based on operational experience.

Table 2: Risks and mitigation

Risk	Mitigation
Preparedness remains procedural and not operational	Require readiness plans to be tested in exercises, linked to real financing and logistics systems, and reviewed regularly against changed conditions; apply the practical readiness standard in section 5.5 to distinguish documented readiness from genuine operational capability
Anticipatory action blocked by indecision	Define trigger conditions, decision authority and financing pathways in advance through approved blueprints; conduct simulation exercises that specifically test the decision authority process under time pressure; make the cost of inaction visible through evidence from previous anticipatory action deployments
Trigger calibration failures producing false positives or false negatives	Design triggers with explicit lead time and probability specifications; review trigger calibration after every season; build a calibration adjustment process into the blueprint review cycle; accept that some false positives are an expected and tolerable feature of any anticipatory system operating under forecast uncertainty
Duplication with existing early warning or DRR institutions	Focus AfHA strictly on the humanitarian interpretation, coordination and action functions; formalise the division of labour with the continental early warning system through a written protocol; apply the complementarity test before developing any new data or analytical capacity

Risk	Mitigation
Uneven regional uptake of anticipatory action systems	Use Regional Centres and REC engagement to tailor support to different regional starting points; sequence blueprint development to begin with the most forecast-ready and institutionally capable regions; share evidence of early action cost-effectiveness to build political support in less engaged regions
Financing not available when triggers are reached	Confirm financing source for every blueprint before classifying it as operational; conduct annual financing readiness review; link the solidarity reserve in the financing framework explicitly to backstop anticipatory action financing when primary windows are insufficient
Cross-border risks under-addressed	Integrate mutual support planning and regional coordination into the seasonal preparedness calendar; develop specific cross-border blueprints for priority transboundary scenarios; ensure Regional Centres have the mandate and resources to facilitate cross-border preparedness
Blueprints not developed or maintained	Establish a continental blueprint register with development schedules and responsibility assignments; gate anticipatory action capability claims on the existence of approved operational blueprints; resource blueprint development explicitly in Phase 1 budget planning

23. Performance indicators

The following indicators provide a minimum framework for assessing the performance of AfHA's preparedness and anticipatory action system. They should be tracked quarterly, reviewed semi-annually through internal management reporting and reported annually to the Governing Board:

Financial release, evidence-product and surge-readiness indicators should be reported through Frameworks 2, 3 and 4 respectively, while this framework tracks whether preparedness and anticipatory action systems are operationally ready and used in practice. Indicative indicators may include:

- number of readiness assessments completed
- number of contingency or preparedness plans supported
- number of trigger-based anticipatory action protocols established
- number of anticipatory actions activated before full crisis escalation
- average time between trigger confirmation and decision on action
- number of cross-border preparedness engagements supported
- proportion of priority regions with active readiness and anticipatory arrangements
- number of after-action reviews informing framework refinement
- number of approved and operational anticipatory action blueprints, disaggregated by hazard type and region
- proportion of approved blueprints with confirmed financing sources
- time from trigger confirmation to activation decision, measured against the lead time available in the relevant blueprint
- time from activation decision to initiation of pre-agreed actions in the field
- number of false positives and false negatives per season, with trend tracking
- proportion of post-action reviews completed and findings integrated into blueprint updates within the required timeframe
- proportion of priority regions covered by the seasonal preparedness calendar and an active seasonal outlook review process

- number of cross-border preparedness scenarios with approved mutual support protocols.

24. Relationship with SOPs to be developed

This framework should be operationalised through a linked set of standard operating procedures. Each SOP provides step-by-step operational guidance that translates the framework's provisions into specific procedures for AfHA staff, Member State and REC focal points, and partners. The following SOPs are required:

- SOP for readiness assessment and contingency planning
- SOP for anticipatory trigger monitoring and action authorisation
- SOP for preparedness coordination with Member States and RECs
- SOP for cross-border preparedness and mutual support planning
- SOP for anticipatory financing activation, aligned with Framework 2
- SOP for preparedness simulation and after-action review, aligned with Framework 4
- SOP for integration of early warning, public health surveillance and humanitarian coordination, aligned with Framework 3 and Framework 1
- SOP for hazard-specific anticipatory action blueprint development, approval, review and maintenance
- SOP for the seasonal preparedness calendar: forecast intake, risk assessment, preparedness action period and post-season review
- SOP for the continental blueprint register: development tracking, operational status classification and annual review
- SOP for cross-border anticipatory action trigger interpretation and multi-country activation

25. Conclusion

The Preparedness, Anticipatory Action and Risk Reduction Framework provides the basis through which AfHA can shift from a largely reactive posture towards a genuinely forward-looking and risk-informed role within the African humanitarian architecture. It recognises that effective humanitarian action begins well before crisis peak, and that coordinated early action depends on systems, trust, readiness and financing that must already be in place when the warning arrives. If implemented consistently, this framework will help AfHA support earlier, better coordinated and more strategic humanitarian action across the continent, while reinforcing African leadership and reducing the human and institutional costs of repeated crisis.

The framework makes five commitments that go significantly further than most preparedness frameworks at the continental level have been willing to make. First, that anticipatory action requires a complete five-element architecture, not merely a trigger threshold: the absence of any single element, whether a pre-authorised action set, a pre-positioned resource, a designated decision authority or a post-action review process, is sufficient to prevent activation at the critical moment. Second, that hazard-specific blueprints are the central operational tool of the anticipatory action system, not an advanced-stage aspiration, and that AfHA cannot claim anticipatory action capability for any scenario for which an approved, resourced blueprint does not exist. Third, that seasonal preparedness calendars are the mechanism through which the warning-to-action timeline is extended from hours to weeks, and that their publication and distribution should be treated as a core annual institutional output on the same level as the financial plan. Fourth, that post-action review, including the systematic assessment of false positives and false negatives, is the primary improvement mechanism for the entire system and should be institutionalised as a standing obligation after every activation and every risk season. Fifth, that this framework's effectiveness depends entirely on the quality of its linkages to the other five frameworks: a preparedness system without financing readiness, information support, surge capacity, data standards and coordination architecture is an aspiration, not an operational system.

The investment required to build a genuine anticipatory action capability is significant, but it is dwarfed by the cost of the alternative. Every major humanitarian response on the continent carries

an implicit price tag composed of lives lost, livelihoods destroyed, displacement costs, logistics premiums, coordination inefficiency and long-term recovery burdens that preparedness and anticipatory action would have reduced. AfHA's most powerful argument with Member States, financing partners and the African public is the simple, evidence-backed claim that acting early is cheaper, faster, more dignified and more effective than acting late. This framework creates the institutional conditions under which AfHA can turn that claim into a demonstrated, repeated and trusted operational practice.

Delivered with the same managed ambition, African ownership and disciplined learning approach that govern the preceding frameworks, the preparedness and anticipatory action system described here has the potential to become AfHA's most consequential contribution to the continent: the mechanism that changes when Africa responds to humanitarian risk, and that progressively shifts the balance of the continent's humanitarian governance from crisis management to crisis prevention.